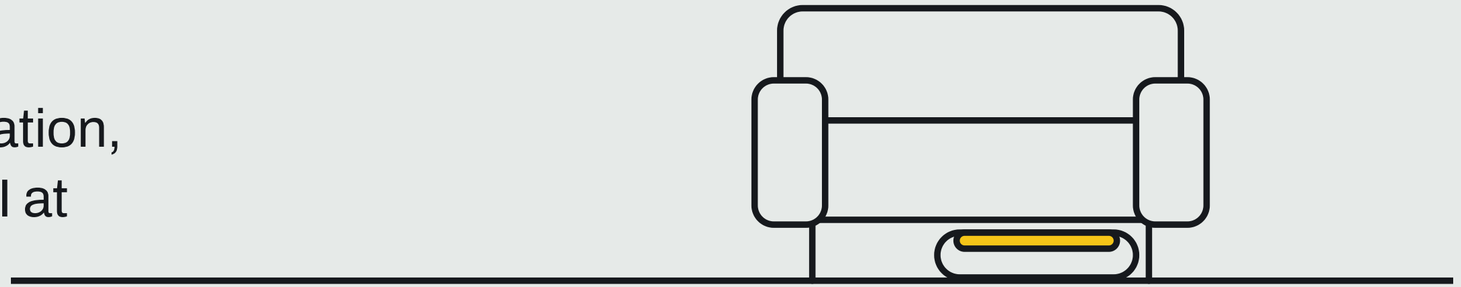
Build the disc, not the butler.

What robotics learned about automation, and what it means for how we use AI at work.



For fifty years we pictured robots doing chores the way we do them.

A butler with arms, pushing the same vacuum you own.

What actually shipped

The winners automated the job, not the person doing it.

Dishes

~~A robot arm scrubbing one plate at a time~~

- Spray jets that wash a full rack at once

Laundry

~~A machine working a washboard~~

- A spinning drum

Floors

~~A humanoid pushing an upright vacuum~~

- A disc that fits under the couch

A vacuum has a handle because a person had to hold it.

Take the person away and the handle is just in the way.

Fig. 1, the butler

PowerPoint is a handle.

Built for a mouse. Drag a box, nudge a font, click through menus.

Familiar to viewers, so it became the default for every kind of message.

Awkward for AI. A complex file format that needs a special library, an MCP server, or Copilot.

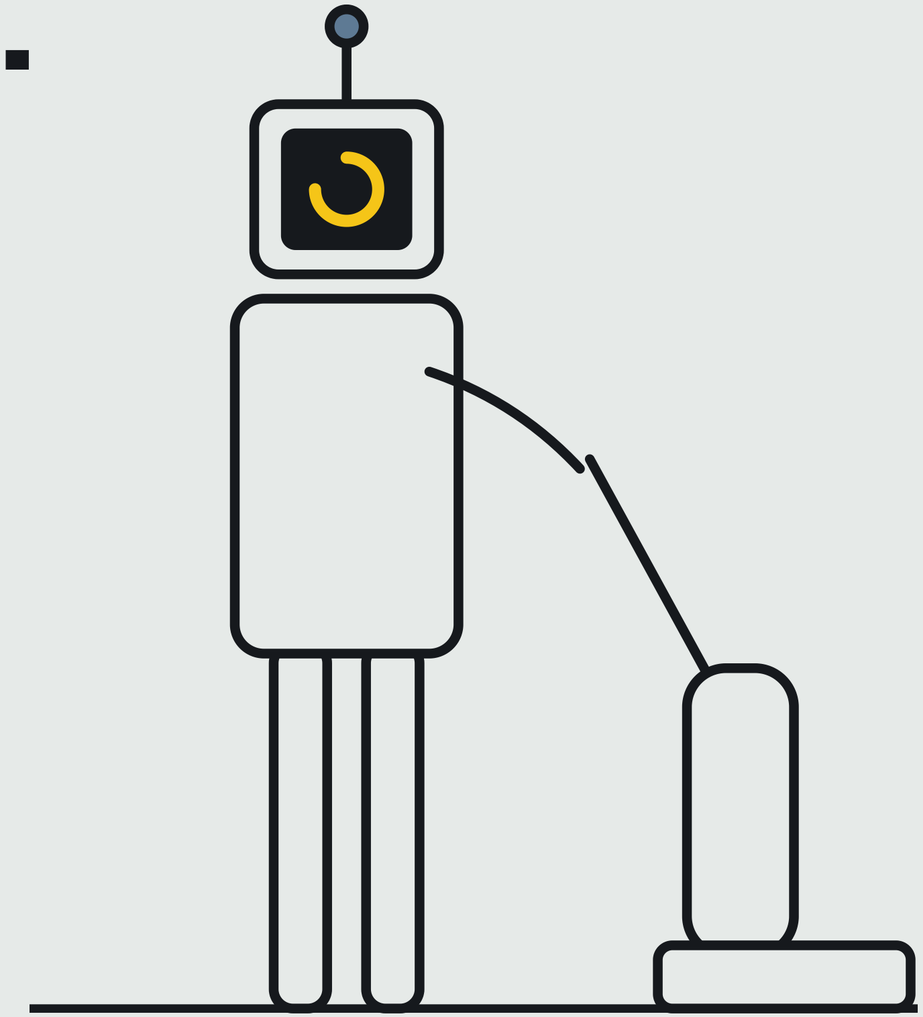
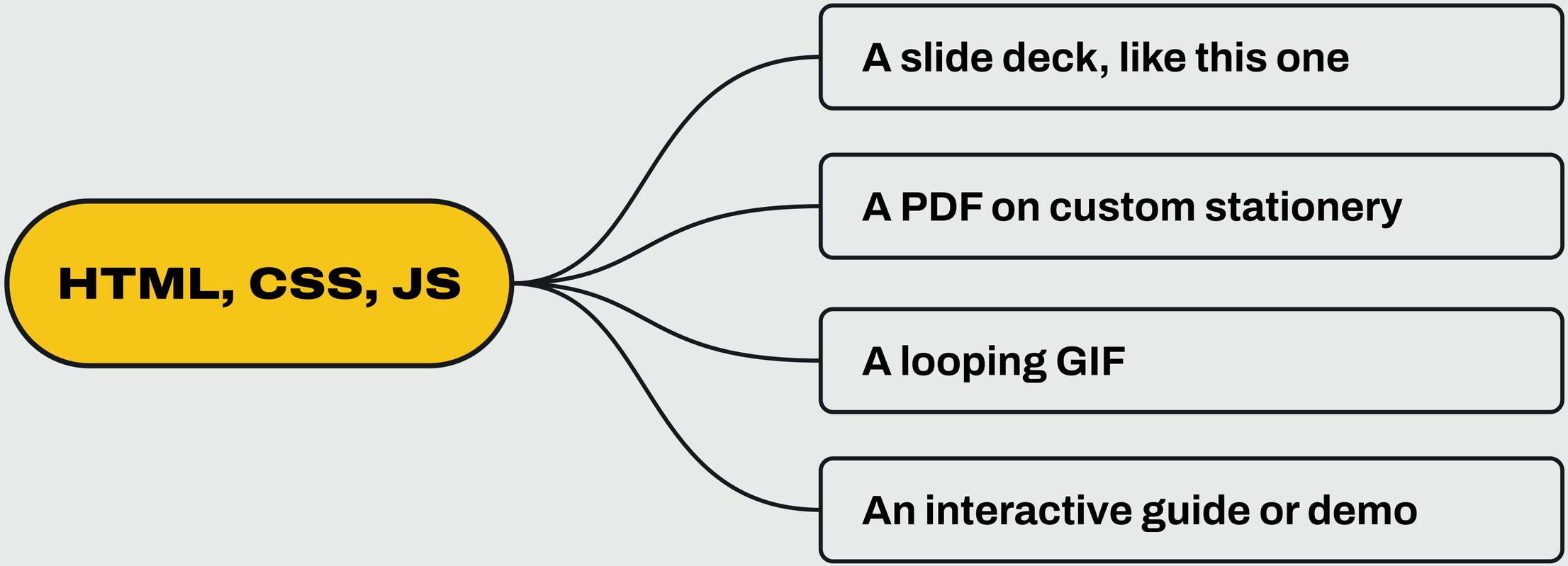


Fig. 2, the disc

AI already speaks the language of the web.



1 file

This deck is a single HTML file. Press **O** for the overview or **N** for speaker notes.

~~How can AI help me make this faster?~~

Now that making things is cheap, what should this actually be?

Build the disc, not the butler.

ai-slide-deck
Decks like this one, exported to PDF

ai-pdf
Documents on custom stationery

ai-gif
Looping motion graphics

Claude Code skills: github.com/htank898/ai-first-comms